Where the Wolves Were

Animals in the place names of Britain and Ireland, from a national gazetteer checked name by name

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Abstract

Place names keep animals long after the animals have gone. I search 145,934 named points from OpenStreetMap (places in the United Kingdom and Ireland, and named hills, woods, cliffs, springs and bays in the United Kingdom) for animal elements in Old English, Old Norse, Welsh, Scottish Gaelic, Irish and later English and Scots, using a conservative, documented word list: whole settlement names whose etymology the standard dictionaries give, the ordinary Celtic-language words for each animal inside each language's area, and English and Scots animal words only beside a landscape word. Of 800 candidates, 30 were removed as known false friends and 26 more on reading every candidate by hand (7.0% in all), leaving 662 places once repeats of a name within 3 km are merged, 189 of them with a certain reading. Wolf names (33) lie at a median 256 m above sea level against 103 m for random names of the same kinds, and most later wolf names are crags and cleughs in the northern hills; boar and deer names stand high too, otter names low. Crane names (23) are English but neither low-lying nor concentrated in the Fens. Eagle names are 68.3% Gaelic, Welsh or Irish, and raven, boar and eagle names survive mainly in Gaelic, while fox and deer names are mainly later English. The old English names on the map were formed while wolves, beavers, cranes and boar still lived here, and have outlived them by four to eight centuries.

Keywords: place names; toponymy; historical ecology; extinct species; wolf; beaver; crane; OpenStreetMap; Old English; Gaelic; Welsh

1 Introduction

Wolves were gone from England by around 1500, beavers by the sixteenth century at the latest, cranes stopped breeding around 1600 and wild boar had left the wild by the thirteenth century (Yalden, 1999; Coles, 2006; Boisseau and Yalden, 1998; Pluskowski, 2006). Place names are one of the few records that place these animals in the landscape of the early medieval centuries. Aybes and Yalden used the English Place-Name Society's county surveys to map the place names of wolves and beavers (Aybes and Yalden, 1995), and Boisseau and Yalden did the same for the crane (Boisseau and Yalden, 1998). Those studies read the scholarly surveys county by county. This paper asks a simpler and more open question of a modern open gazetteer: across Britain and Ireland, which named places and hills keep an animal in their name, in which languages, and where?

The answer depends on care with false friends. Wolverhampton is named after a woman, Wulfrun; Eagle in Lincolnshire is an oak wood; Swanage is the farm of herdsmen; many *Brock-* names are brooks, and many Irish *Cran-* names are trees. So the method is conservative, every rule is written down, and every candidate was read by eye.

2 Data

Names. Three OpenStreetMap extracts, queried with QLever (Bast and Buchhold, 2017): 106,905 place nodes in the United Kingdom (city, town, village, hamlet, suburb, neighbourhood, quarter, locality, farm and isolated dwelling) with `name`, `name:cy` and `name:gd`; 24,964 named natural features in the United Kingdom (peaks, hills, ridges, valleys, woods, cliffs, springs, bays and an island); and 14,065 place nodes in Ireland with `name:ga`. Each point is assigned a county and nation from the ONS boundaries and a ground height from the AWS Terrain Tiles at zoom 10 (about 90 m).

Etymologies. English and Norse settlement names follow the standard dictionaries (Mills, 2011; Watts, 2004; Ekwall, 1960) with Gelling and Cole (2000) on the landscape words; Welsh, Gaelic and Irish words are read in their ordinary dictionary sense, with Owen and Morgan (2007) and Watson (1926) for the place-name patterns.

3 Method

Three kinds of rule (`code/elements.py`, `data/elements.csv`). (1) *Named*: 69 English or Norse settlement names that the dictionaries explain with an animal (Table 3), matched as whole names with optional prefixes such as Great or Upper and a short list of suffixes (Abbey, Common, Green, Heath, a saint's name), only on settlements, and only in the county of the dictionary's place where that is known. Names that recur (Hartley, Woolley, Foxley) are marked probable outside the county I am sure of. (2) *Word*: 37 rules for the Welsh, Scottish Gaelic and Irish words for each animal, with their mutated and genitive forms (Welsh *blaidd*, *bleiddiaid*; Gaelic *iolair*, *na h-iolaire*; *fitheach*, *an fhithich*; Irish *broc*, *na mbroc*), applied to `name` and the language tag, inside Wales, Scotland or Ireland respectively. (3) *Modern*: 22 rules for English and Scots animal words (wolf, eagle, raven, crane, hart, hind, deer, stag, brock, badger, fox, tod, cat, otter, swan, kite, glede, boar), only followed by a landscape word (crag, hill, knowe, cleugh, hole, scar, nest, tor, law and others), and never on farms, single houses or modern suburbs. Gaelic *madadh* alone can be a dog, a fox or a wolf; its 23 names are kept apart and not counted.

False friends and review. 23 exclusion patterns remove known false friends (Table 2). I then read all 800 candidates and dropped or corrected 26 more in a documented overrides file, for example Donnybrook (Domhnach Broc, St Broc's church), Brackagh (usually Irish *breacach*, speckled), Colmonell (St Colmán Ela), Arbirlot (the Elliot Water), and inn signs such as Stags Head. Rules changed in review too: *buck* was removed because Old English *bucc* can be a he-goat, and *roe* because Roedean is a rough valley. In all 7.0% of candidates were removed. Every candidate, with the reason it was kept or dropped, is in `data/candidates_review.csv`.

Places. Repeats of one name for one animal within 3 km (Woolpit, Woolpit Green, Woolpit Heath) are counted as one place (82 names merged), leaving 662 places.

Height test. For each animal, the median ground height of its UK places is compared with the median of random UK names of the same kinds (the same numbers of peaks, villages, localities and so on), drawn 20,000 times; the one-sided p-value is the share of draws at least as high (or as low).

Table 1: Places by animal: total, with a certain reading, by language (Old English, Old Norse, Welsh, Scottish Gaelic, Irish, later English or Scots), and the median ground height (m) of UK places against that expected for random names of the same kinds, with the one-sided p-value (+ higher, − lower than expected; 20,000 draws).

Animal	Places	Certain	OE	ON	Wel	Gae	Ir	Later	Height	Expected	p
Deer	150	47	33	0	7	28	2	80	252	136	0.000+
Fox	147	22	14	0	5	9	2	117	144	123	0.104+
Raven	93	38	0	0	2	36	0	55	224	169	0.025+
Badger	59	6	3	0	0	3	17	36	141	129	0.342+
Wildcat	55	1	4	0	1	9	1	40	202	135	0.015+
Eagle	41	31	6	0	4	23	1	7	230	216	0.378+
Wolf	33	4	8	1	3	0	0	21	256	103	0.000+
Crane	23	9	11	1	0	0	0	11	103	86	0.240+
Wild boar	22	17	5	0	0	15	0	2	334	129	0.000+
Otter	15	9	5	0	1	3	0	6	36	73	0.052−
Swan	9	1	2	0	0	1	0	6			
Kite	9	0	1	0	0	0	0	8			
Beaver	3	2	3	0	0	0	0	0			
Salmon	3	2	0	1	0	1	0	1			

4 Results

4.1 The animals

Table 1 gives the places for each animal. Deer (150), fox (147) and raven (93) lead; wolf has 33, eagle 41, crane 23, wild boar 22 and beaver only 3. By language, 95 places are Old English, 3 Old Norse, 23 Welsh, 128 Scottish Gaelic, 23 Irish and 390 later English or Scots. 189 (28.5%) have a certain reading.

4.2 Wolves in the uplands

The certain wolf names are few: Woolpit in Suffolk (Old English *wulf-pytt*, a pit for trapping wolves), Woolley in West Yorkshire, Ulpha in Cumbria (Old Norse *ulfr* and *haugr*) and Welsh Cwm Bleiddiaid. A farm called simply Blaidd is kept as probable, since a one-word house name may be modern. Most wolf names are later English and Scots names of crags, cleughs and holes: 73.3% of the 30 English-language wolf names lie north of 53.5°N. The median wolf place stands at 256 m, against 103 m expected for names of the same kinds; no random draw was as high ($p < 0.0001$). Because the descriptive rules accept only names with a landscape word, the draw from all names of a kind flatters every animal named in that way; among the descriptive English and Scots names alone, wolf names stand at a median 289 m against 224 m for all such names, and against the other animals' kept names of the same kind and rule family (old or descriptive) the wolf names are still higher (148 m expected, $p = 0.003$). Wild boar (334 m against 129 m) and deer (252 m against 136 m) are also high; ravens ($p = 0.02$) and wildcats ($p = 0.01$) somewhat high; fox ($p = 0.10$), badger, eagle and crane names lie about where expected, and otter names low (36 m against 73 m, $p = 0.05$; 0.02 against other animals' names), as expected for a river animal, though with only 15 places the result is weak.

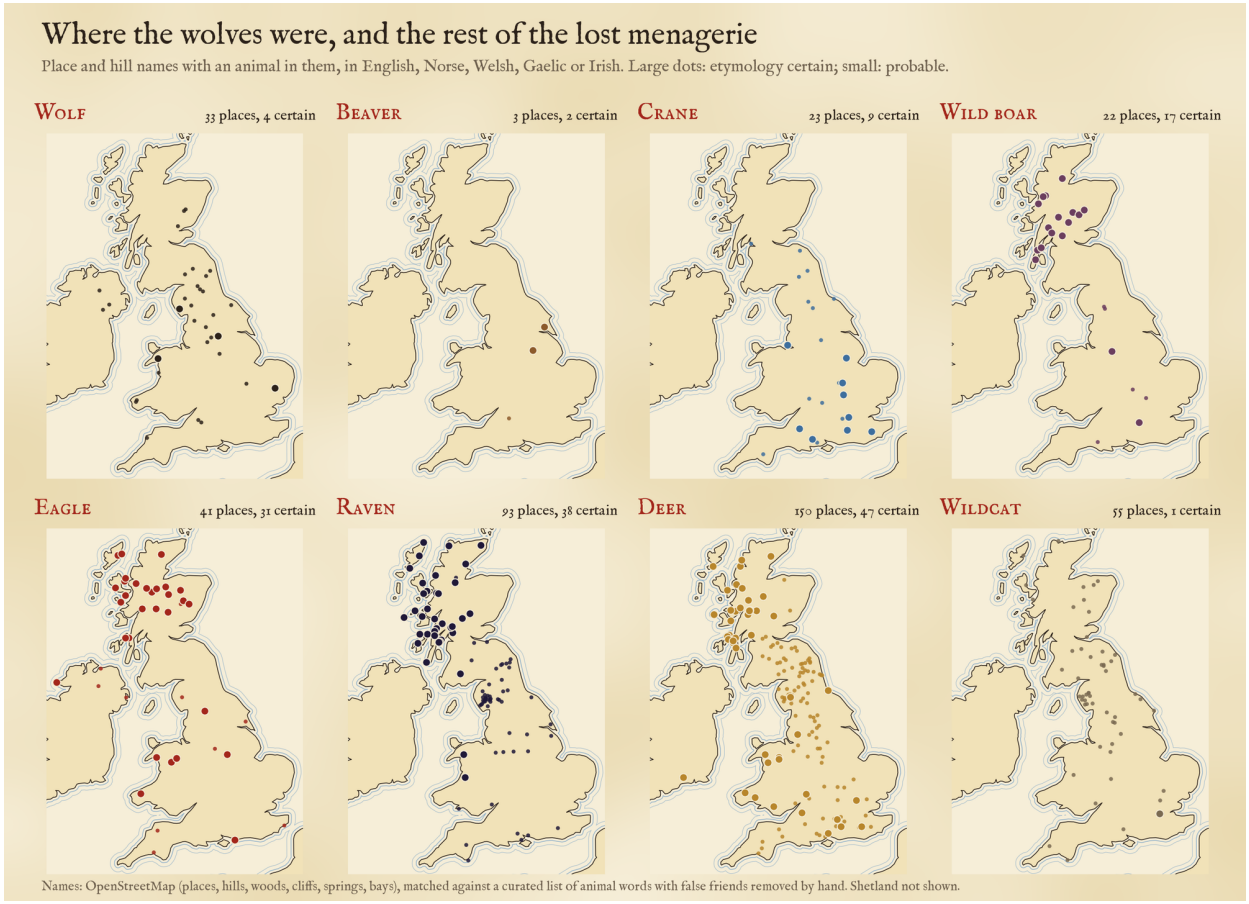


Figure 1: Places named for eight animals. Large dots: certain reading; small: probable.

4.3 Cranes and beavers

The crane names are 91.3% English: Cranfield, Cranbrook, Cranborne, Cranford, Cranmore, Cranwell, Cranleigh and Norse Tranmere. Old English *cran* may also have meant the heron, and the dictionaries often gloss it so. They are not concentrated in the Fens: only 1 lies in Cambridgeshire, Lincolnshire, Norfolk or Suffolk, and their median height (103 m) is close to that expected (86 m, $p = 0.77$ for lower). The beaver leaves only Beverley, Bevercotes and Beversbrook in this gazetteer, far fewer than the field and minor names found in the county surveys (Aybes and Yalden, 1995).

4.4 Languages

Animals differ in the language that keeps them (Figure 4). Eagle names are 68.3% Gaelic, Welsh or Irish (23 Gaelic *iolair*, 4 Welsh *eryr*, 1 Irish *iolar*) and only 6 Old English *earn*: Arncliffe, Earnley, Arnold, Yarnscombe and Ernesettle. Raven names are Gaelic *fitheach* in the west Highlands and English crag names in the north of England (58.2% of the English ones in Cumbria and Northumberland). Boar names are mostly Gaelic *tuirc* hills. Fox and deer, animals that never left, are named mostly in later English and Scots.

4.5 Where names are densest

One 10 km square of the British National Grid in Cumbria, in the fells around Dunnerdale, holds names for 4 animals. By county, Northumberland has 16.0 animal places per 1,000 named points,

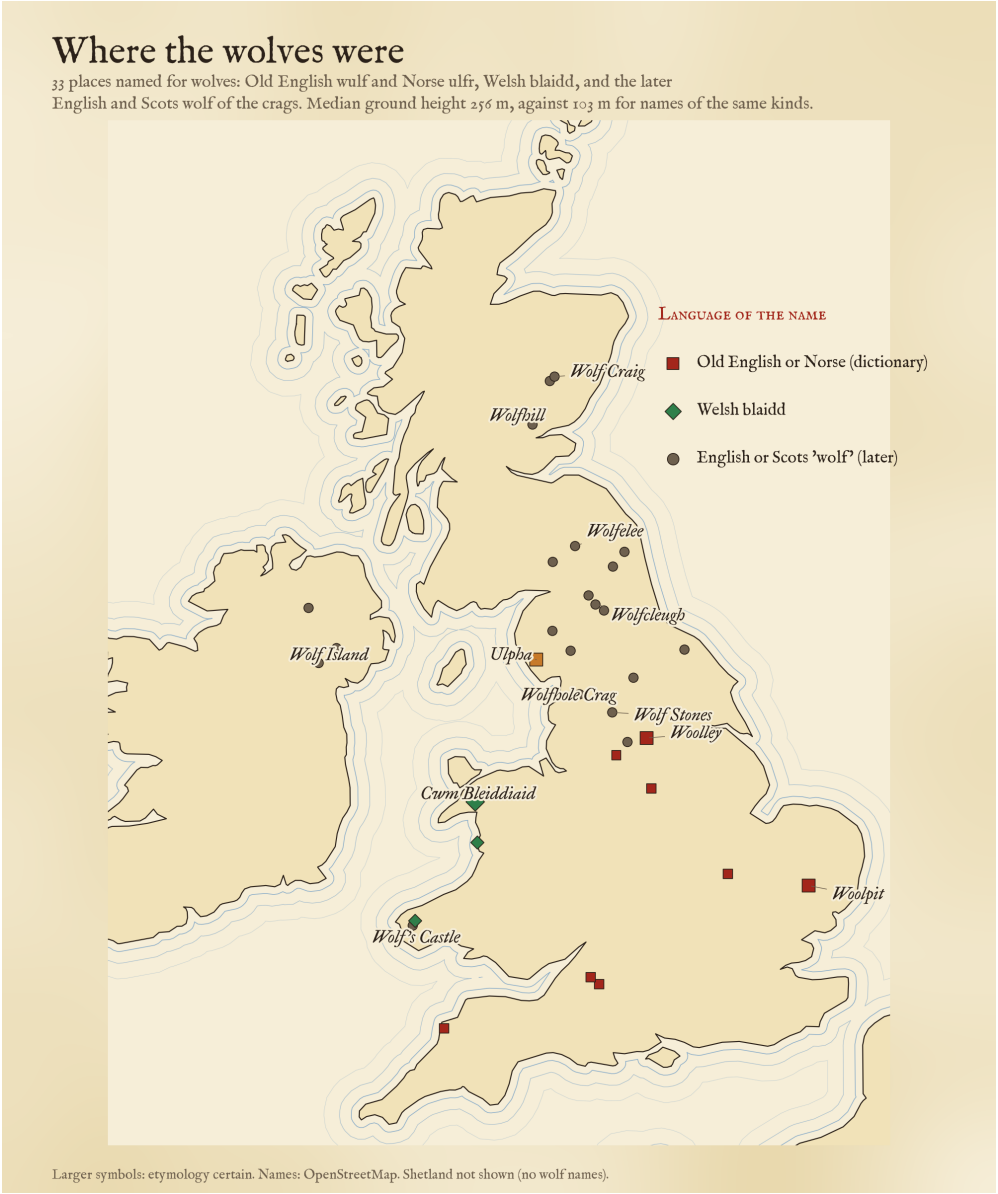


Figure 2: Wolf names by language.

Argyll and Bute 13.2 and Cumbria 11.2 (counties with at least 1,000 named points), against 4.9 for the UK. Upland counties with many named crags and knowes lead.

4.6 Names and losses

Figure 6 sets the names against the dates the animals were lost. Wild boar were gone from the wild in the thirteenth century, with park herds into the seventeenth (Yalden, 1999); wolves around 1500 in England, in the late seventeenth or eighteenth century in Scotland (Yalden, 1999; Pluskowski, 2006) and in 1786 in Ireland (Hickey, 2000); beavers by the sixteenth century at the latest, and perhaps centuries earlier, a date still debated (Coles, 2006); cranes as breeding birds around 1600 (Boisseau and Yalden, 1998); and the white-tailed eagle in 1918, reintroduced to Rum from 1975 (Love, 1983). There is no reliable bear name in these data.

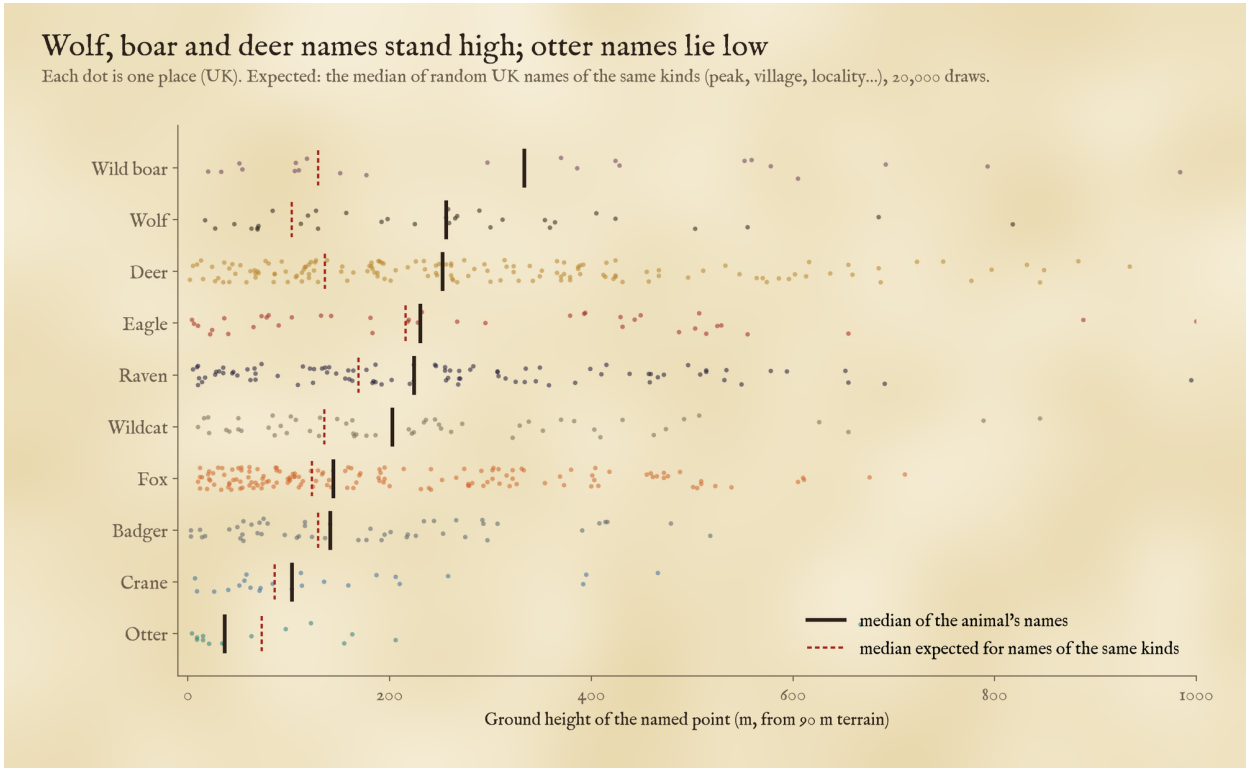


Figure 3: Ground height of each UK place by animal: median (black) and the median expected for random names of the same kinds (red, dashed).

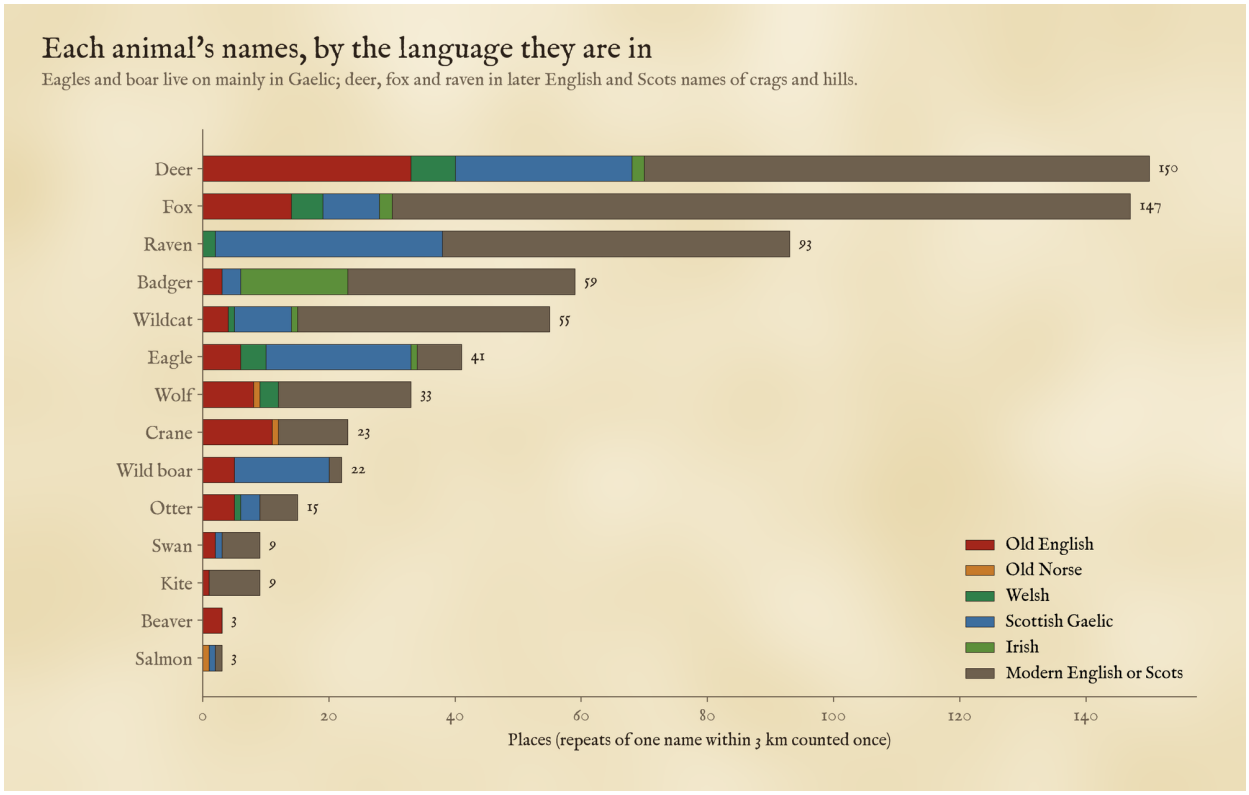


Figure 4: Places by animal and language.

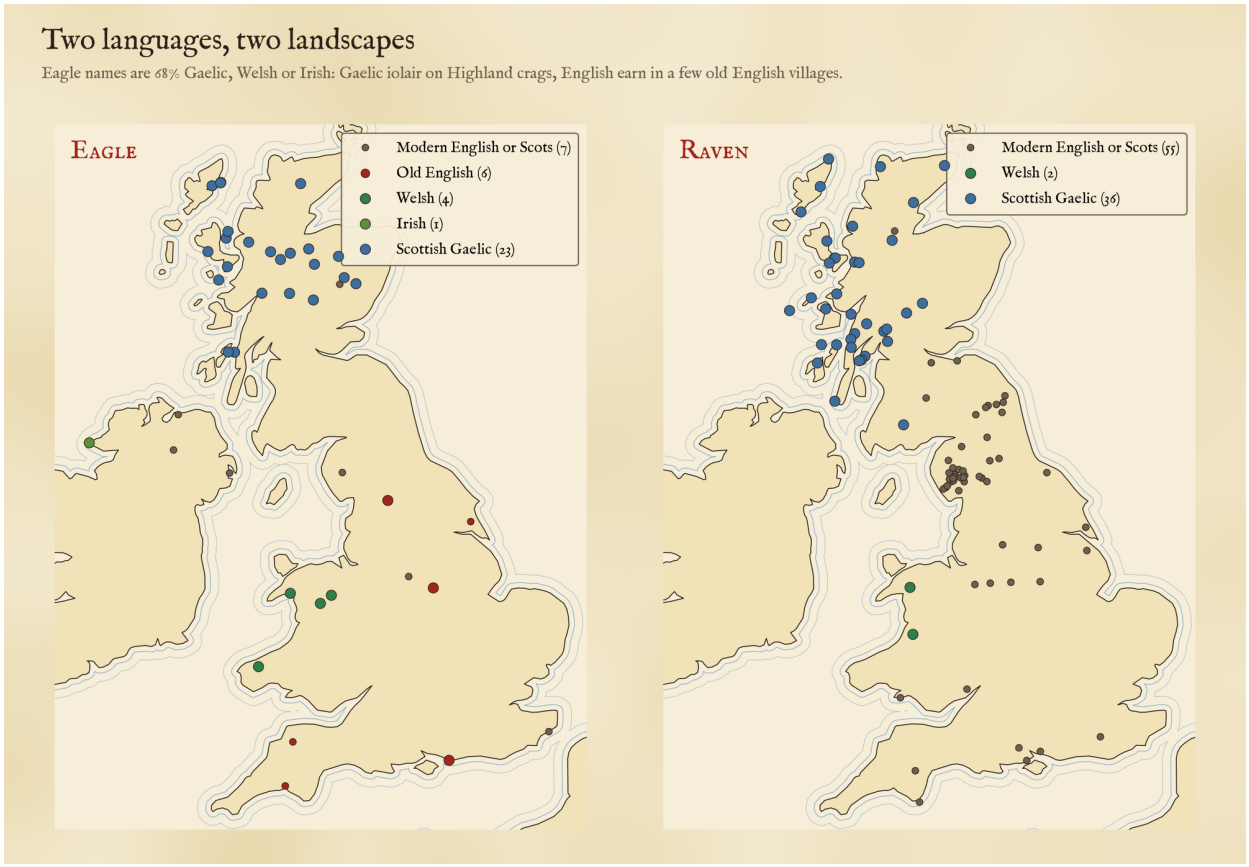


Figure 5: Eagle and raven names by language.

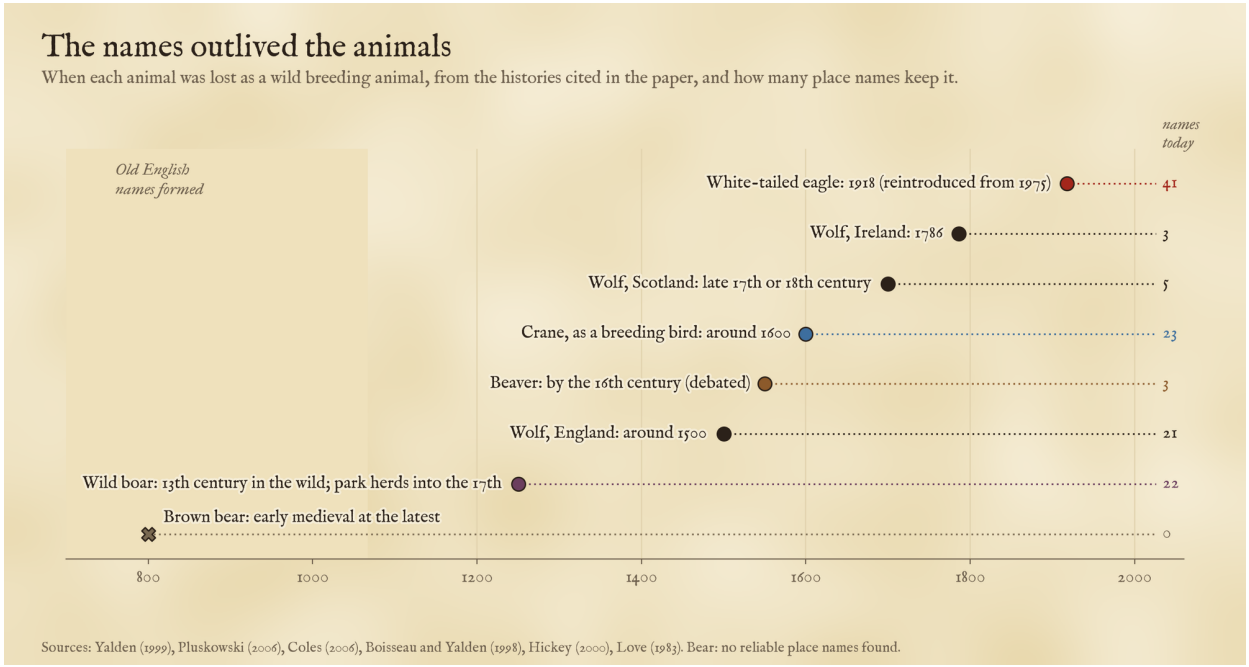


Figure 6: When each animal was lost in the wild, and the number of places keeping its name.

Table 2: Some false friends removed by rule or in review.

Name	Looks like	Is
Wolverhampton	wolf	Wulfrun's high farm, after a woman's name
Eagle (Lincolnshire)	eagle	Old English ac-leah, oak wood
Eaglesham	eagle	Gaelic eaglais, a church
Swanage	swan	Old English swan, herdsmen
Roedean	roe deer	Old English ruh denu, rough valley
Brockley	badger	a brook, or a personal name
Cranagh	crane	Irish crann, a tree
Donnybrook	badger	Domhnach Broc, St Broc's church

Table 3: The named rules: English and Norse settlement names read with an animal after the standard dictionaries (Mills 2011; Watts 2004; Ekwall 1960), the counties where they apply and the certainty given.

Name	Animal	Element	Meaning	Counties	Reading
Woolpit	Wolf	OE wulf-pytt	pit for trapping wolves	Suffolk	certain
Woolley	Wolf	OE wulf + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by wolves	West Yorkshire	certain
Woolley	Wolf	OE wulf + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by wolves (as the Yorkshire Woolley; not checked for this one)	any	probable
Ulpha	Wolf	ON ulfr + haugr	hill frequented by wolves	Cumbria	certain
Wolf's Castle	Wolf	Welsh Casblaidd, blaidd	the wolf's castle (Welsh Casblaidd)	Dyfed	probable
Beverley	Beaver	OE beofor + a stream name	beaver stream or beaver lodge	East Riding of Yorkshire	certain
Bevercotes	Beaver	OE beofor + cot	beavers' lodges, shelters for beavers	Nottinghamshire	certain
Beversbrook	Beaver	OE beofor + brōc	beavers' brook	Wiltshire	probable
Cranfield	Crane	OE cran + feld	open land frequented by cranes or herons	Bedfordshire	certain
Cranbrook	Crane	OE cran + brōc	brook frequented by cranes or herons	Kent	certain
Cranborne	Crane	OE cran + burna	stream frequented by cranes or herons	Dorset	certain
Cranbourne	Crane	OE cran + burna	stream frequented by cranes or herons	Berkshire	probable
Cranford	Crane	OE cran + ford	ford frequented by cranes or herons	Greater London, Northampton-shire	certain
Cranmore	Crane	OE cran + mere	pool frequented by cranes or herons	Somerset	certain
Cranwell	Crane	OE cran + wella	spring or stream frequented by cranes or herons	Lincolnshire	certain
Cranleigh	Crane	OE cran + lēah	clearing frequented by cranes or herons	Surrey	certain
Cransley	Crane	OE cran + lēah	clearing frequented by cranes or herons	Northamptonshire	probable

Table 3: The named rules: English and Norse settlement names read with an animal after the standard dictionaries (Mills 2011; Watts 2004; Ekwall 1960), the counties where they apply and the certainty given.

Name	Animal	Element	Meaning	Counties	Reading
Tranmere	Crane	ON trani + melr	sandbank frequented by cranes	Merseyside	certain
Cranshaws	Crane	OE cran + sceaga	wood frequented by cranes or herons	Scottish Borders	probable
Arncliffe	Eagle	OE earn + clif	cliff frequented by eagles	North Yorkshire	certain
Earnley	Eagle	OE earn + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by eagles	West Sussex	certain
Arnold	Eagle	OE earn + halh	nook of land frequented by eagles	Nottinghamshire	certain
Arnold	Eagle	OE earn + halh	nook of land frequented by eagles	East Riding of Yorkshire	probable
Yarnscombe	Eagle	OE earn + cumb	valley of the eagles	Devon	probable
Ernesettle	Eagle	OE earn + setl	eagle's seat or eyrie	Devon	probable
Everley	Wild boar	OE eofor + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by wild boar	Wiltshire, North Yorkshire	certain
Eversley	Wild boar	OE eofor + lēah	wood or clearing of the wild boar	Hampshire	certain
Evershot	Wild boar	OE eofor + scēat	corner of land frequented by wild boar	Dorset	probable
Eversholt	Wild boar	OE eofor + holt	wood frequented by wild boar	Bedfordshire	probable
Everdon	Wild boar	OE eofor + dūn	hill frequented by wild boar	Northamptonshire	probable
Wildboarclough	Wild boar	ME wilde bor + OE clōh	ravine frequented by wild boar	Cheshire	certain
Hertford	Deer	OE heorot + ford	ford frequented by harts	Hertfordshire	certain
Hartlepool	Deer	OE heorot + ēg + pōl	pool by the hart island (Heruteu)	Durham	certain
Hartfield	Deer	OE heorot + feld	open land frequented by harts	East Sussex	certain
Hartley	Deer	OE heorot + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by harts	any	probable
Hartley Wintney	Deer	OE heorot + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by harts	Hampshire	certain
Hartford	Deer	OE heorot + ford	ford frequented by harts	Cheshire, Cambridgeshire, Northumberland	probable
Harthill	Deer	OE heorot + hyll	hill frequented by harts	South Yorkshire, Cheshire, North Lanarkshire	probable
Hartshead	Deer	OE heorot + hēafod	the hart's headland or hill	West Yorkshire	probable
Hartsop	Deer	OE heorot + hop	valley of the hart	Cumbria	certain
Hartshorne	Deer	OE heorot + horn	hart's horn, a hill shaped like one	Derbyshire	probable

Table 3: The named rules: English and Norse settlement names read with an animal after the standard dictionaries (Mills 2011; Watts 2004; Ekwall 1960), the counties where they apply and the certainty given.

Name	Animal	Element	Meaning	Counties	Reading
Hartwell	Deer	OE heorot + wella	spring frequented by harts	Buckinghamshire, Northampton-shire	probable
Hartburn	Deer	OE heorot + burna	stream frequented by harts	Northumberland, Durham	probable
Hindhead	Deer	OE hind + hēafod	hill frequented by hinds	Surrey	certain
Hindley	Deer	OE hind + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by hinds	Greater Manchester	certain
Darley	Deer	OE dēor + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by deer	Derbyshire, North Yorkshire	probable
Durley	Deer	OE dēor + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by deer	Hampshire	certain
Deerhurst	Deer	OE dēor + hyrst	wooded hill frequented by deer	Gloucestershire	certain
Dyrham	Deer	OE dēor + hamm	enclosed valley or deer enclosure	Gloucestershire	certain
Dearham	Deer	OE dēor + hām or hamm	homestead or enclosure where deer are kept	Cumbria	probable
Brockhall	Badger	OE brocc + hol	badger holes (setts)	Northamptonshire	certain
Brockholes	Badger	OE brocc + hol	badger holes (setts)	West Yorkshire, Lancashire	certain
Foxley	Fox	OE fox + lēah	wood or clearing frequented by foxes	England	certain
Foxholes	Fox	OE fox + hol	fox holes, earths	North Yorkshire	certain
Foxearth	Fox	OE fox + eorth	fox's earth	Essex	certain
Foxcote	Fox	OE fox + cot	fox's earth or den	any	probable
Foxhall	Fox	OE fox + hol	fox hole	Suffolk	probable
Foxton	Fox	OE fox + denu or tūn	valley or farm frequented by foxes	Leicestershire, Cambridgeshire, Durham, North Yorkshire	probable
Catford	Wildcat	OE catt + ford	ford frequented by (wild) cats	Greater London	certain
Catcleugh	Wildcat	OE catt + clōh	ravine of the (wild) cats	Northumberland, Scottish Borders	probable
Catshill	Wildcat	OE catt + hyll	hill frequented by (wild) cats	Worcestershire	probable
Otterburn	Otter	OE otor + burna	otter stream	Northumberland, North Yorkshire	certain
Otterbourne	Otter	OE otor + burna	otter stream	Hampshire	certain
Ottery St Mary	Otter	OE otor + ēa (River Otter)	on the River Otter, 'otter stream'	Devon	certain
Otterton	Otter	OE otor + ēa + tūn (River Otter)	farm on the River Otter, 'otter stream'	Devon	certain
Leixlip	Salmon	ON lax + hlaup	salmon leap	any	certain
Swanmore	Swan	OE swan + mere	pool frequented by swans	Hampshire	probable
Swanbourne	Swan	OE swan + burna	stream frequented by swans	Buckinghamshire	probable

Table 3: The named rules: English and Norse settlement names read with an animal after the standard dictionaries (Mills 2011; Watts 2004; Ekwall 1960), the counties where they apply and the certainty given.

Name	Animal	Element	Meaning	Counties	Reading
Gledhow	Kite	OE gleoda + hōh	hill spur frequented by kites	West Yorkshire	probable

5 Limitations

A name records what someone noticed, feared or joked about when it was given, not a population; one wolf pit or crane-haunted pool tells us little about numbers. OpenStreetMap is a gazetteer of present-day points, uneven in coverage between regions and mappers, and almost without the field names and minor names where most wildlife names are recorded, which is why the counts here are far smaller than those from the county surveys (Aybes and Yalden, 1995). The dictionary readings are the standard ones but some are debated, and the individual etymologies were applied from the dictionaries without re-examining early spellings. The descriptive English and Scots names may honour a surname, an inn sign or a story rather than a living animal, and are marked probable. Gaelic and Welsh coverage depends on whether the Gaelic or Welsh form is the OpenStreetMap name or tagged; Wales in particular is under-counted. Ground heights are from 90 m terrain at the mapped point.

6 Conclusion

Read carefully, an open gazetteer gives a fair sketch of the animals in British and Irish place names: wolves on northern crags and in a few old English villages, cranes and beavers in English settlement names, eagles, ravens and boar in Gaelic hills, and the common animals in the later names of the land. The names have outlived the wolves, beavers, cranes and boar by four to eight centuries. Every rule, decision and name is published so that others can correct and extend the list.

Data and code availability

The interactive map is at https://maps.tristanhotham.com/animal-place-names/. Code, the element list, the overrides and every candidate with its decision are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/animal-place-names and archived with this paper at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.24075293. The name tables are derived from OpenStreetMap (© OpenStreetMap contributors) and released under the Open Database Licence; text and figures CC BY 4.0; code MIT. Ground heights from the AWS Terrain Tiles; county boundaries from the ONS (Open Government Licence v3.0).

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

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